

Proposal ROI Worksheet

How much is your proposal process actually costing you — and what would your team and revenue look like if AI handled the drafting alongside them?

From HitLai Institute — Module S1: “AI That Wins You More Business”

THE MATH NOBODY DOES

Most business owners say “proposals take too long” but never translate that into a dollar figure. Here’s the 10-minute exercise that does.

Fill this in once. Keep the result on your desk. When you evaluate any AI tool or subscription, check it against this number — not against a theoretical ROI calculator the vendor sent you.

STEP 1: WHAT DOES A PROPOSAL ACTUALLY COST YOU TODAY?

Line	Your number
A. Average hours to research, draft, edit, and send one proposal	_____ hrs
B. Hourly cost of the person doing it (salary ÷ 2,000, or your own rate)	\$_____ /hr
C. Cost per proposal (A × B)	\$_____
D. Proposals sent per month	_____
E. Monthly cost of proposal work (C × D)	\$_____
F. Annual cost (E × 12)	\$_____

STEP 2: WHAT’S THE OPPORTUNITY COST?

Time spent on proposals is time NOT spent on selling, delivery, or strategy.

Line	Your number
G. Hours per month on proposal work (A × D)	_____ hrs
H. Of those hours, how many are <i>creative</i> vs <i>copy-paste-and-formatting</i> ? Estimate % copy-paste	_____ %
I. Recoverable hours per month (G × H)	_____ hrs
J. Recoverable annual hours (I × 12)	_____ hrs

If J is over 240 hours, you’ve lost 6 weeks of a full-time person to administrative proposal work. That’s not a “productivity” problem — it’s a hiring decision you’re making by default.

STEP 3: WHAT DOES SPEED BUY YOU?

Response time correlates directly with win rate. Industry benchmarks:

- Proposal sent **same day**: 35-50% win rate
- Proposal sent **within 3 days**: 20-30% win rate
- Proposal sent **after 7 days**: under 15% win rate (prospect often stops replying)

Line	Your number
K. Current average turnaround (hours/days from inquiry to send)	_____
L. Deals lost per year to slow response (your best estimate)	_____
M. Average deal size	\$_____
N. Annual revenue lost to slow proposals (L × M)	\$_____

STEP 4: THE “AI + YOUR TEAM + YOUR SYSTEMS” REALITY

When AI drafts alongside your team — pulling data from your CRM, locking on your approved pricing, routing to your reviewer in the systems they already use:

- Turnaround drops from [your K] to 30-60 minutes
- Quality goes up (nothing forgotten, consistent pricing, no typos)
- Volume capacity goes up (you can send 3-5x more proposals with the same people)

Line	Your number
O. Estimated time per proposal with AI draft + your review	_____ hrs
P. New monthly cost ($O \times B \times D$)	\$_____
Q. Monthly savings ($E - P$)	\$_____
R. Annual savings ($Q \times 12$)	\$_____

STEP 5: THE HONEST SUBSCRIPTION-COST CHECK

Any AI tool or platform should pay for itself on THIS line alone. Everything else is a bonus.

Line	Your number
S. Monthly subscription cost of the tool you're evaluating	\$_____
T. Net monthly savings ($Q - S$)	\$_____
U. Break-even: how many proposals/month must you send? ($S \div [C - (O \times B)]$)	_____

If **T** is positive and **U** is lower than **D**, the math works. If it isn't, either the tool is wrong for you or you need to honestly re-examine A, D, or B.

WHERE CHATGPT ALONE STOPS HELPING

ChatGPT is great at the *draft*. It does nothing for:

- Pricing drift across team members
- Proposals that never get logged or tracked
- Follow-ups that fall through the cracks
- The 40 minutes of copy-paste between AI, CRM, email, and calendar
- A consistent record of what your team sent, when, on whose approval

The value of getting AI, your team, and your systems running together is the *remaining* time the draft alone didn't solve.

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS PAGE

Fill it in now with real numbers — not ideals. Put the annual savings figure (R) somewhere you'll see it weekly.

If R is under \$5,000/year, proposal automation isn't your highest-value workflow — come to Module S2 (customer response) or S3 (paperwork) instead.

If R is over \$15,000/year, you've just built a business case for any AI-assisted proposal flow priced up to about \$1,250/month to be a clear win.

THE HITLAI ANSWER, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

AI tools, your team, your systems — running together, safely.

For the proposal use case: your CRM data feeds the draft, your approved pricing is the source of truth, your team gets the draft in their normal approval queue, send and follow-up get scheduled in the same flow. AI starts where you're comfortable — watching, suggesting, or executing-with-approval — and earns the right to do more.

Works with Microsoft 365, your CRM, the AI you already use. What we don't have a connector for, the platform builds automatically in minutes, reviewed before it goes live. Every step is auditable.

Want help filling this in with real data from your CRM? Bring your laptop to the next HitLai Institute in-person module. We'll pull your numbers live and set up a proposal flow you can use the next morning.

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